

BRIDGE THE DIGITAL DIVIDE FOR ALL

► Despite being the world's second-largest smartphone and internet market, just over 40% of Indians remain offline, and more than half lack smartphones. Digital inclusion must go beyond connectivity to affordable devices, local-language content, and digital literacy. Targeted schemes for rural and marginalised communities are crucial. A true digital economy demands that every Indian, regardless of income or geography, can participate fully in online services, education, and economic opportunities.

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ETHICAL AI

► Introduce a comprehensive AI Regulation and Ethics Law that mandates ethical AI audits, bias checks, and data consent disclosures for all large-scale AI deployments, along with compulsory watermarking of AI-generated content, strict penalties for malicious deepfake usage, and oversight by an independent AI ethics authority to ensure transparency, accountability, and responsible innovation. Criminalise malicious use, especially in political, financial, or personal harm contexts, with strict penalties and takedown timelines.

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STREAMLINE PATENTS, SPUR INNOVATION

► India's patent system has to be faster, clearer, and more transparent. Huge backlogs, complex processes, and inconsistent enforcement discourage start-ups and inventors. Reforms should include faster examination timelines, simplified filing procedures, and robust IP enforcement. Improving patent rules can attract R&D investment, protect homegrown technologies, and boost India's position as a global innovation hub. A strong IP regime is the bedrock of a thriving digital and industrial economy.

